

I adored Lee. I hated how neither she nor my parents could fund her move. Once she finally did retire and come to Florida, she almost immediately was diagnosed with colon cancer and died at only 68. This fueled my theory that your days are numbered and even if you did the right thing and retired only when it was responsible to do so, you could still up and die without ever enjoying your freedom.

I'm sure Meme feels the same way, and I can't blame her. Once she was liberated from the concentration camps, she married an American soldier and emigrated from Paris to South Bend, Indiana, of all places. She gave birth to my father when she was 20 years old, had another daughter, and went through one more husband, an abusive man, before meeting my grandfather Pepe in the 1950s. Pepe was an anesthesiologist who made good money and was well regarded in the community. Meme and Pepe absolutely loved each other, but as Marilyn Monroe said in the film *Gentlemen Prefer Blondes*, "Don't you know that a man being rich is like a girl being pretty? You wouldn't marry a girl just because she's pretty but my goodness, doesn't it help?"

After they were married, Meme bought expensive jewelry, antique art, and fine clothing. Pepe wore cashmere sweaters and nice watches. (When he passed away, I inherited a Burberry scarf.)

"So you guys were rich?" I asked.

"We were comfortable. I don't call it rich." (Classic Meme dodge.)



Asking your family specific money questions is like opening Pandora's box. I have one friend who spends all of April silencing her dad's phone calls because it stresses her out too much to hear about their taxes. Most of my peers don't know the full extent of their family's money histories. If you don't ask the questions, you never have to think about it, and most of my friends don't want to think about it. If I didn't know the reality of my family's financial situation, I could pretend it wasn't so fraught. If I hadn't sat down to interview my family members, I wouldn't have to face this truth: how Meme and Pepe saved and spent while my parents struggled. It's a hard pill to swallow.